

MAKING A LAST DITCH EFFORT

The Americans take to hard sell in a bid to convince BJP about the merits of the deal even as they sweet talk the Left. But both parties are sticking to their stated opposition to it.

■ **By Priya Sahgal and Saurabh Shukla**

It's the great American hard sell. As the Indo-US nuclear deal totters, powerful American representatives, last week, embarked on a feverish last ditch campaign to convince the political opposition to yield. Much like salesmen, they were busy addressing seminars and business fora, sipping coffee with the Right or talking investments with the Left. First they held out the promise. "The deal is very important for India's economic growth and energy security," said Henry Paulson, US treasury secretary when he called on West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya on October 28. The very next day, Henry Kissinger, a former secretary of state, accompanied by a former US ambassador to India Frank Wisner had a cup of coffee with L.K. Advani. The man who was responsible for America's pro-Pakistan tilt in the 1970s sang a different tune as he tried to convince the leader of the Opposition that it was India's interests that he had come to project. On the same day, US Ambassador David Mulford called on Rajnath Singh and enquired first about the BJP chief's planned trip to the US early next year. Then he made his pitch about the merits of the deal.

Next, the American interlocutors, like all good salesmen, pointed to the downsides if there was no buy. BJP sources say both Advani and Rajnath got the distinct impression that the underlying American message held out a threat: if the deal did not go through, it would leave an indelible scar on the Indo-US relations. After Advani told Kissinger that BJP's opposition to the deal remained despite the 40-minute

interaction, the former American diplomat told a television channel that the scrapping of the deal would impact negotiations on other areas of co-operation between the two countries. While he had tea and pastries with Rajnath, Mulford tried to sell the deal by highlighting the expiry date pointing out that the next US government may not give India such a "special status". According to a BJP MP, "He talked about trust and hinted that this could impact the Indo-US relations." In response, Rajnath told Mulford that there was a difference between BJP and the Left's opposition to the deal. While the Left's opposition was ideological, BJP was worried that the deal in its current form was against India's strategic interests.

The Americans are hoping that they are preaching to the converted and possibly saw BJP as easier to convince than the Left. But BJP leaders told the US interlocutors that the party was firm in its opposition to the deal. When Mulford told Rajnath that it was a civil nuclear deal and not a defence or a strategic deal, Rajnath responded that nuclear energy was related to defence, no matter what the deal was called.

Mulford also called on former national security advisor Brajesh Mishra and tried to allay his concerns. He reminded both Mishra and Advani that this was after all a deal initiated by NDA. "It is ironical to see the Americans coming here to convince us that the deal is in Indian interest," says Prakash Javdekar, BJP spokesperson. "But even after hearing them out BJP sticks to its original position that the deal is not acceptable." BJP now says it is considering debating the deal in Parliament without pressing for a vote on the floor of the House. The emphasis too has

